

CHAPTER 17

IN VIYYUR JAIL, RIPPER FOR COMPANY

'Did you count the number of bars on the cell gate?'

After a sleepless night, terrified of the rats, I waited for the jail staff to open the cell. Through the night I had kept my ears open to hear for any approaching rodent. Not that I could do anything—I did not have anything in my hand to even shoo them away. At day break I searched for the nuisance and found them huddled in a corner.

When the jailor came to ask us to get ready to leave for Viyyur Central Prison, the only question in my mind was if the cell there would be as bad as this. After a couple of hours drive from Ernakulam we reached the Central Prison, a much bigger place. We were herded to a section of the prison, which I later realised was the high-security zone. It had twenty-four cells in a row.

Each cell had a toilet in a corner, without much of an enclosure separating the shit hole from the rest of the space. The cells on this corridor were numbered one totwenty-four. As we passed the second cell, the inmate shouted in Malayalam: '*Saare…avanmaar ningaleyum kurukkiyo*?' (Sir, those guys have trapped you too).

It would be a while before I realise that this prisoner was Ripper, a serial killer who used a hammer to break the skull of his victims. Kerala had seen a couple of such 'Rippers', and I do not remember this man's real name. He was about 5'3" tall. He looked malnourished, but had great energy when he spoke, his volume always high. He had escaped from the Poojapura Central